

Sales Training — Session 35

Ground Yourself.

The 90/10 Rule. Sell You First.

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WHAT THIS SESSION IS The deeper layer beneath every closing technique. Why power words don't work in a vacuum. Why "let me think about it" is almost never about the product. Why 90% of every successful pitch is the rep and the brand — and only 10% is the product. The grounding move that makes the rest of the playbook click.

1. Power words come from the ground — not from a list

Power words work — but only if they're connected to something real. A rep can have the perfect list on their desk and still sound rehearsed if the words aren't connected to genuine belief. "Perfect, fantastic, sophisticated, opportunity" are powerful when they come from a rep who means them and inert when they don't. The buyer can hear the difference in under three seconds.

This is why the session's central claim is that power words aren't a vocabulary skill — they're a grounding skill. The rep who is genuinely grounded in self, company, and offer will naturally generate power words mid-pitch without ever having to retrieve them from a list. The rep who isn't grounded sounds rehearsed no matter which words they pick. Same words, completely different sale.

"The power word is not something that comes out the mouth. It comes out the heart. Heart is a power word — for me, because I do everything with heart. The list works because you mean it."

2. Certainty wins — the rule of the most certain person

A working principle: in any sales conversation, the person with the highest level of certainty has the highest probability of getting their point across. This isn't about who's right — it's about who SOUNDS most confident in what they're claiming. Buyers default to the source that seems most sure of itself, because uncertainty triggers their own uncertainty, and they retreat to safe choices (which usually means saying no).

The rep's job is to BE the most certain voice in the conversation. That doesn't mean overclaiming results or pretending to know things they don't. It means knowing — with conviction — what the agency does well, what the rep believes about the work, and what the rep is willing to stand behind. Certainty about the things you actually know beats false certainty about everything every time.

"He or she who is most certain has the highest probability of getting their point across. Certainty about what you know beats false certainty about everything — by a wide margin."

The corollary: if the rep is uncertain, the buyer feels it. If the buyer feels uncertainty, they delay. A delayed deal is almost always a lost deal. So the rep's job pre-call is to identify the things they ARE certain about — and lean into those. Don't bluff the rest. Just be solid on what you actually have.

3. The grounding stack — You → Company → Product

The session's central diagram. Most reps pitch in the wrong order: they lead with the product, talk about the company in passing, and never really sell themselves. The order that actually closes deals is the reverse. You first. Then the company. Then — almost as an afterthought — the product.

Why this order? The buyer has to trust three things before they can buy. First, the human being on the other end of the call. Second, the organisation that human represents. Third, the offering. Trust accumulates upward, not downward. If the buyer doesn't trust the rep, no amount of company credibility or product detail will close them. If the buyer trusts the rep but not the company, the rep can still credibly defer to corporate strengths. If the buyer trusts both, the product almost sells itself.

"You need to value yourself first. Then you need to value the company. Then everything else is easy. The buyer is buying you, then the company. The product is almost incidental."

Practical move: before any call, the rep mentally runs the stack. Am I grounded in who I am? Am I grounded in why I work here? Can I name one specific reason this agency is the right place for the buyer's problem? If all three answer yes, the call writes itself. If any answer no, the rep should pause and answer it before dialling.

4. "I could have worked anywhere — I chose this place"

A specific line worth memorising. When the rep wants to establish themselves as a credible, choosing, grounded human, the line is: "I could have worked anywhere I wanted — and I chose this place. Let me tell you why." The line works because it accomplishes three things at once. It signals the rep has options (so they're not desperate). It implies the rep made a deliberate choice (so the rep believes in what they're doing). And it creates a small narrative gap — "why?" — that the buyer wants to hear answered.

The line only works if the rep actually has a real answer to the "why." That's the homework. Every rep on the team should be able to deliver, off the top of their head, two or three specific reasons they chose this agency. Not generic ("the team is great"). Specific ("the customer service overhaul Corie just ran — I haven't seen another agency willing to do that kind of work"). The specifics are what makes the line land.

"I could have worked anywhere. I chose this place. Let me tell you why."

Practical move: every rep should spend 30 minutes writing down their own "why" — three specific reasons they chose this agency, in their own words. Not Corie's reasons. The rep's. The exercise feels awkward; the payoff is immediate. Once the rep has their own genuine "why," the line lands every time they use it.

5. The boxer's punch — power comes from the ground

A physical metaphor for what grounding actually means. Watch a boxer throw a punch. The power doesn't come from the arm — it comes from the feet. The boxer drives off the back foot, transfers weight through the hip, and the arm is the last part of the chain. A punch thrown from the arm alone is weak. A punch driven from the ground is devastating. Same arm, completely different power.

Sales works exactly the same way. The rep's words are the arm. The grounding — the rep's belief in themselves, the company, the work — is the ground. Words spoken without grounding land softly. The same words spoken with grounding behind them land hard. Buyers feel the difference immediately, even if they can't articulate it. They just sense "this person means it" versus "this person is selling."

"Where does a boxer's power come from? The ground. You're the ground. The punch — the words — means nothing unless it's driven from down here."

6. "Let me think about it" — what it actually means

One of the most common end-of-pitch responses. "That all sounds good — let me have a think about it." Most reps interpret this as the buyer wanting to get other quotes, comparison-shop, or run the numbers. The session offered a different reading.

"Let me think about it" usually means: I'm not clear about YOU. Not about the product. Not about the price. Not about the timeline. About the human being who just spent 30 minutes pitching me. The buyer can evaluate the product fine — they can ask follow-up questions, request a proposal, compare quotes. What they can't evaluate, and what the delay usually surfaces, is whether they trust the rep.

"They're saying 'let me think about it.' What they're really saying is — I'm not clear about you. Not the product. You."

If this reading is correct (and Corie's claim is that it usually is), the fix isn't more product detail in the follow-up. The fix is more YOU. Send a personal note, not a brochure. Mention something specific from the conversation that proves the rep was listening. Reference the buyer's situation in language that shows the rep cares. The buyer needs to see one more data point on the human — not the product.

7. The Filipino Airlines thought experiment

Corie's longest analogy in the session, worth working through carefully. Imagine boarding two different international flights for a holiday.

Flight A: The crew look distracted. They keep glancing at the wings. They take your ticket without warmth. There's a faint smell of fuel in the cabin. How do you feel?

Flight B: The crew greet you warmly. They help you with your bag. They settle you into your seat and ask if you need anything. There's a faint smell of fuel in the cabin (because every plane smells like fuel — that's normal). How do you feel?

In Flight A you're tense for the whole flight. The fuel smell makes you nervous. Every small bump on the runway feels alarming. In Flight B you forget about the fuel smell completely. You read your book. The flight feels safe. Same plane. Same fuel. Same physics. The only variable was the crew's connection to the brand.

"Same plane. Same fuel. Same physics. The only thing that changed was how the crew showed up. That's your job. You're the crew. You decide whether the buyer feels safe or whether they smell fuel."

Applied to sales: the rep IS the cabin crew. Their tone, their warmth, their evident connection to the agency — all of it shapes whether the buyer interprets normal friction (price, contract length, technical detail) as red flags or as ordinary parts of the journey. A grounded rep makes the buyer feel safe. An ungrounded rep makes everything feel like fuel.

8. The 90/10 rule — what's actually being bought

The central thesis of the session. In any successful pitch, roughly 90% of what closes the buyer is the rep + the brand. Only about 10% is the product. This isn't a rhetorical claim — it's the operating ratio observed across the agency's top-performing reps over years.

This is why technical depth matters less than reps usually think. The buyer is going to spend two minutes evaluating SEO and 25 minutes evaluating the rep. The rep who internalises this stops trying to win the call on product depth and starts winning it on grounding, certainty, and connection. The product detail is what closes the last 10% — and that's only if the first 90% is already in place. Without the first 90%, no amount of product detail makes a difference.

"90% of every transaction has nothing to do with technical know-how. 90% is how you're connected to the brand and how you feel about the brand. 10% is the product."

Inverted, the same insight: reps who lose deals usually blame the product ("the price was too high," "the contract was too long"). What actually happened was a failure in the first 90% — the buyer didn't trust the rep or didn't connect with the brand. The product just became the polite reason the buyer cited. Real failure analysis happens upstream, in the grounding.

9. Every meeting is a job interview

A reframe that sharpens the rep's preparation. Every prospect meeting should be treated as if the rep is interviewing for a job — the job of being the buyer's marketing partner. The frame produces all the right behaviours: the rep arrives slightly early, dresses appropriately, prepares specific examples, listens more than they talk, and asks thoughtful questions about the buyer's business.

Most reps don't do this — they treat prospect meetings as pitches to deliver rather than conversations to earn. The job-interview frame inverts that. The rep is the candidate. The buyer is the interviewer. The rep's job is to make the interviewer want to hire them. Pitching at the buyer feels like begging for the job. Earning the role feels like worth getting hired.

"Every face-to-face is a job interview. You're not pitching — you're being interviewed. Prepare like that. Show up like that. The hiring rate goes up."

10. Action items for the team

1. Spend 30 minutes this week writing down three SPECIFIC reasons you chose this agency. Not generic. Specific. Memorise them.
2. Practise the line "I could have worked anywhere — I chose this place" out loud until it lands naturally. Follow with your specific reasons.
3. Before any call: run the grounding stack mentally. Am I grounded in self? Company? The fit between this agency and this buyer? Yes / yes / yes before dialling.
4. Identify the things you ARE certain about. Lean into those. Don't bluff the rest. Buyers smell uncertainty instantly.
5. When a buyer says "let me think about it," assume they mean "I'm not clear about YOU." Follow up with personal, not product. Reference something specific from the conversation.
6. Treat every prospect meeting as a job interview. Arrive prepared. Listen more than you talk. Earn the role.
7. After every closed deal, write down what the buyer actually responded to. You'll discover it was rarely the product detail. Use those notes to recalibrate.

THE RULE OF THUMB Power words come from the ground. The ground is you. Sell yourself first. The company second. The product third. The buyer doesn't smell fuel when the crew is warm — and they don't ask "can I think about it?" when they're already certain about you.